



The America-250 Date Sheet

*Five fixed dates in the semiquincentennial window — verified, sourced,
stamped*

FREE · INSTANT DIGITAL DOWNLOAD

Liberty Line — patriotism & America 250

The America-250 Date Sheet

Five fixed dates in the semiquincentennial window — what happened, why it matters, and where to check it yourself.

> **Last verified: August 13, 2026.** > Every date and claim below was checked against at least two independent, reputable sources on that > day. The sources are named under each entry so you can confirm them yourself in about five minutes. > Nothing on this sheet expires the day after a holiday — these are anniversary dates of events that > already happened, and they will still be true in 2031.

How to use this sheet

America's 250th is not one day. It is a **window** — running from the 250th anniversary of Lexington and Concord in April 2025 to the 250th anniversary of the Treaty of Paris in September 2033. The Declaration is the centerpiece, but it is not the whole story, and the story does not stop on July 5th.

Five dates below. One line each on what happened, one line on why it matters, and the sources. Print it, put it on the refrigerator, and you will always have something true to say at the cookout.

Two dates already observed (kept here because they anchor the window): April 19, 2025 — the 250th of Lexington and Concord, the first shots of the war. June 14, 2025 — the 250th of the Continental Army, raised by resolution of the Continental Congress the day before it named its commander.

1. July 4, 2026 — the 250th of the Declaration of Independence

What happened (1776): On July 2, 1776, the Second Continental Congress voted to separate from Great Britain. On **July 4** it approved the final wording of the Declaration

of Independence and ordered it printed. The famous engrossed parchment most Americans picture was signed later, beginning August 2, 1776.

Why it matters: July 4 marks the day the *text* was adopted — the argument, not the vote and not the signing. That distinction is the single most retellable fact on this sheet, and it is the reason John Adams thought the country would celebrate the second of July.

Verify it:

- National Archives, "Declaration of Independence" (the founding documents collection) — adoption
July 4, 1776; engrossed copy signed beginning August 2.
- Library of Congress, *Journals of the Continental Congress, 1774–1789*, volume 5 — the July 2 vote
and the July 4 adoption entries, in the Congress's own minutes.

2. December 26, 2026 and January 3, 2027 — the 250ths of Trenton and Princeton

What happened (1776–77): Washington crossed the Delaware on the night of December 25–26, 1776, and took the Hessian garrison at Trenton in a morning action. Nine days later, on January 3, 1777, he slipped around the British force sent to trap him and won again at Princeton.

Why it matters: These two weeks are the reason there was still an army in 1777. Enlistments were expiring, the campaign of 1776 had been a string of retreats, and a war that looked finished was not.

Verify it:

- National Park Service, Washington Crossing / Princeton Battlefield historical pages — dates and
sequence of the Ten Crucial Days.

- Library of Congress, *George Washington Papers* — Washington's own correspondence from late December 1776 and early January 1777.
-

3. October 17, 2027 — the 250th of Saratoga

What happened (1777): After defeats at Freeman's Farm and Bemis Heights, British General John Burgoyne surrendered his army near Saratoga, New York, on **October 17, 1777**.

Why it matters: Saratoga is the hinge. The surrender of an entire British army persuaded France that the Americans could win, and the formal French alliance followed in February 1778 — which is what turned a colonial rebellion into a war Britain had to fight on several oceans at once.

Verify it:

- National Park Service, Saratoga National Historical Park — surrender date and campaign summary.
 - Library of Congress / Yale Law School Avalon Project — Treaty of Alliance with France, February 6, 1778, showing the diplomatic consequence.
-

4. October 19, 2031 — the 250th of Yorktown

What happened (1781): After a siege by combined American and French forces, with a French fleet holding the Chesapeake, Lord Cornwallis's army surrendered at Yorktown, Virginia, on **October 19, 1781**.

Why it matters: This is the end of major fighting in North America, not the end of the war. The war was legally still on for nearly two more years — a fact almost everyone gets wrong.

Verify it:

- National Park Service, Colonial National Historical Park (Yorktown Battlefield) — surrender date
and the Articles of Capitulation.
 - Library of Congress, *George Washington Papers* — the Articles of Capitulation, Yorktown, dated
October 19, 1781.
-

5. September 3, 2033 — the 250th of the Treaty of Paris

What happened (1783): American and British commissioners signed the definitive Treaty of Paris on **September 3, 1783**. Britain recognized the United States as free and independent. The Confederation Congress ratified it on January 14, 1784.

Why it matters: This is the actual close of the semiquincentennial window — independence declared in 1776 became independence acknowledged in 1783. Seven years and two months separate the two.

Verify it:

- National Archives, Milestone Documents — Treaty of Paris (1783), signing date and text.
 - Yale Law School Avalon Project, "Treaty of Paris, 1783" — the full treaty text with signature date.
-

The window, at a glance

Date	250th of	Status as of August 13, 2026
April 19, 2025	Lexington and Concord	Observed
June 14, 2025	Founding of the Continental Army	Observed
July 4, 2026	Adoption of the Declaration	Observed

Date	250th of	Status as of August 13, 2026
December 26, 2026	Battle of Trenton	Upcoming
January 3, 2027	Battle of Princeton	Upcoming
October 17, 2027	Surrender at Saratoga	Upcoming
October 19, 2031	Surrender at Yorktown	Upcoming
September 3, 2033	Treaty of Paris signed	Upcoming

Three things people get wrong

1. **"The Declaration was signed on July 4."** It was *adopted* on July 4, 1776. Most signatures went on the engrossed parchment starting August 2.
 2. **"Yorktown ended the war."** Yorktown ended the major fighting in October 1781. The war ended legally with the Treaty of Paris, September 3, 1783.
 3. **"America 250 is a one-day event."** The anniversaries run through 2033. There is a 250th worth marking almost every year between now and then.
-

How this sheet is kept honest

Each entry names two independent sources — a federal record-keeping body (the National Archives, the Library of Congress, or the National Park Service) plus a second primary-document source. Where the sources disagree on a detail, the primary document wins, and the disagreement is stated rather than smoothed over.

If you find an error, we would genuinely like to know. The stamp at the top is not decoration: a fact sheet with no verification date is asking you to take its word for it,

and we would rather you didn't have to.

Last verified: August 13, 2026 — Liberty Line.